



KISHOR PATHAK

THE DEATH TRAP

- Food and water shortage in forest areas and laying of railway tracks through elephant corridors
- Steep embankments on either side of the track, sharp and blind turns, and poor visibility
- Throwing of waste food on the tracks, lack of awareness among train drivers about elephant corridors and not following speed limits in such areas
- Unscientific attitude of the Railways and state forest departments and no cohesion between them
- Non-availability of modern alarm systems based on sensor or radar technologies

THE WAY OUT

- The forest departments must take measures to prevent shrinkage of animal habitats; the railways should consult wildlife experts before laying new track
- Wherever possible, the railways must level down the embankments and increase the gap between embankments and tracks
- Passengers and drivers should be sensitised about elephant corridors; strict punishment for drivers for not following speed limits
- A joint committee should be set up between the railways and forest departments
- IIT Roorkee is working on an alert system

Kerala Forest Minister Benoy Viswam also alleges non-cooperation from the Railways. "I had written to the Railways Minister Mamata Banerjee in June but got no response from her," says Viswam. Palakkad Railway Division Manager S.K. Singh says that the railways is ready to spend half the money needed in reduction of elephant deaths if the forest departments take appropriate steps. While the Kerala Forest Department has gone for solar electric fencing and trenching on the 10-km track on its part, the Tamil Nadu Government has decided to follow suit but has requested the railways to share the cost. Assam Forest Minister Rockybul Hussain says that a 24-hour elephant control force is in operation while electrical fencing has been erected at some vulnerable places. "We have implemented some measures like coming up with plantations favoured by elephants so that they do not venture out in search of food," says Hussain.

Many believe that constructing rail lines on elevated ground or concrete pillars and building tunnels in forests will ensure smooth movement for animals. Several organisations have demanded diversion of railway tracks from elephant corridors, but the railways find such solutions impractical as laying down of one km track costs around Rs 3-30 crore. "The speed limit near the Deepor Beel area is 20 kmph. We have also trained the drivers about elephant movements," says Hajong. The Southern Railway has also brought down the speed of the trains to 65 kmph from 90 kmph on the Palakkad-Coimbatore track but refuses to reduce further as the stretch is on a gradient.

The WRI has initiated a project in Assam in association with the railways and Forest Department to replicate its success in Uttarakhand where 21 elephants were killed between 1992 and 2002. Various steps like night patrols, awareness campaign for train drivers

and flattening of steep embankments have ensured no deaths since 2002 along the track passing through the Rajaji National Park.

Siddiqui believes that technology should play a vital role in tackling the situation. "We must get the best professionals to develop either alarms or thermal imagery systems which can be installed in rail engines and cabins and at level crossings so that elephants can be detected from far distances." The WRI has approached IIT Roorkee to develop an alert system based on sensor or radar technology.

Article 51A (g) of the Indian Constitution states: It is the duty of every citizen of India to protect and improve the natural environment including forests, lakes, rivers and wildlife, and to have compassion for living creatures. It's high time both the railways and forest departments followed this constitutional guideline in true spirit.

with Subhash Mishra and Kaushik Deka